72% Rise in complaints against unregistered telemarketers from 2021 to 2024

9 Times more complaints against unregistered telemarketers than those against registered ones in 2024

system have started tightening the screws on such telemarketing sweatshops, officially called UTMs—the ones the system doesn't have a count of. Ordinary SIM cards are purchased in bulk under company names without informing telecom providers that they'll be used for telemarketing. The exact number of such users remains unknown. However, the system does not classify all commercial communication as a spam. Some people may be looking for real estate and choose to opt in to receive such messages temporarily, opting out once their need is met.

Similarly, banks can send promotional messages to customers, and so on. For these use cases, there are registered telemarketers. India has some 19,100 of them. Typically, they are call centres acting for 290,000 Principal Entities (PEs) like banks and insurance companies. Commercial communications are sent via headers like 'SBICRD' for SBI Credit Cards, allowing users to recognise senders. The DLT platform currently maintains 320,000 headers and 6.82 million SMS templates.

Hidden Menace

Some actors play dirty, disrupting systems designed to protect consumers. From January to October last year, complaints against registered telemarketers reached 163,000, while those against unregistered ones soared to a staggering 1.47 million—nine times higher.

UTMs remain the bigger problem, since they operate under the radar. These entities bypass regulations by using regular 10-digit numbers or bulk-purchased SIM cards. The result? A 72 per cent rise in complaints against UTMs since 2021. "We have disconnected 18.5 lakh mobile numbers and blacklisted 1,100 entities/individuals involved in unsolicited commercial communications," Scindia says. Such entities or individuals will not get any telecom resources for two years.

For years, Swedish multinational Truecaller has pretty much been the only 'shield' consumers had against spams.

INTERVIEW
JYOTIRADITYA SCINDIA



RAJWANT RAWAT

Ordinary SIM cards are purchased in bulk under company names without informing telecom providers that they will be used for telemarketing

Crowdsourcing and harnessing contacts from users since 2009, Truecaller has built a global database in which users label calls and messages as 'spams', 'frauds', 'scams' to help users identify and avoid them. Its 2024 global report identified India as the top country of origin for spam calls in the US. But if India was one of the top sources of spam calls, the study also recognised it as among the countries most affected by spam calls.

The war against spam is one all countries are fighting. In the US, the Federal Communications Commission (FCC) has made concerted efforts in this direction. The Telephone Robocall Abuse Criminal Enforcement and Deterrence Act has given law enforcement agencies more teeth to fight illegal 'robocalls'. The FCC has also banned AI-generated voices in telemarketing calls. In Europe, too, the rules are strict. For example, Spain put a law in place in 2023 that bans commercial calls without the person's consent beforehand. Violators are liable to pay fines up to €100,000.